CHAPTER 6

BHAKTI-SUFI TRADITIONS

CHAPTER ESSENCE AT A GLANCE:
Master medieval religious developments (8th to 18th centuries): Alvars and Nayanars of Tamil Nadu, Virashaivas of Karnataka, Sufism and Chishti Silsila, Kabir's syncretic poetry, and Guru Nanak's Baba Nanak legacy.

4 CORE PRINCIPLES TO UNDERSTAND FIRST

• **Saguna vs Nirguna Bhakti Traditions:** Saguna bhakti worships specific anthropomorphic divine incarnations (Vishnu, Shiva, Devi); Nirguna bhakti worships an abstract, formless, attribute-less Supreme Reality.

• **South Indian Pioneer Movements:** Alvars (devotees of Vishnu - Nalayira Divyaprabandham) and Nayanars (devotees of Shiva - Tevaram) challenged Buddhist and Jain dominance and caste barriers; produced revered female poets (Andal, Karaikkal Ammaiyar).

• **Virashaiva Lingayats and Sufi Silsilas:** Basavanna founded Virashaivism in Karnataka, advocating vachanas and Linga worship; Sufi orders (Chishti Silsila founded in India by Khwaja Muinuddin Chishti) practiced zikr, sama, and hospice (khanqah) charity.

• **Syncretic Voices: Kabir and Guru Nanak:** Kabir critiqued external rituals of both Hinduism and Islam using ulatbansi verses; Guru Nanak founded Sikhism advocating Shabad, Nam-Simran, Langar communal kitchens, and rejected caste.

ESSENTIAL HISTORICAL CHRONOLOGIES & THEMES

$$\text{Bhakti Modes} \rightarrow \{\text{Saguna: Anthropomorphic Incarnations,} \quad \text{Nirguna: Formless Transcendent Absolute}\}$$

Theological Dualism in Medieval Devotional Poetry

$$\text{Tamil Bhakti Literature} \iff \text{Alvars (Nalayira Divyaprabandham)} + \text{Nayanars (Tevaram)}$$

Vernacular Devotional Canons Equated with the Vedas

$$\text{Chishti Silsila Lineage} \iff \text{Muinuddin (Ajmer)} \rightarrow \text{Qutbuddin} \rightarrow \text{Farid} \rightarrow \text{Nizamuddin (Delhi)}$$

Spiritual Genealogy of Major Indian Sufi Masters

$$\text{Guru Nanak Triad} \iff \text{Nam-Japna (Remembrance)} + \text{Kirat-Karni (Honest Work)} + \text{Vand-Chhakkna (Sharing)}$$

Foundational Ethical Pillar Framework of Sikh Panth

CRUCIAL EXAM PRECAUTIONS & VALUATION RUBRIC SECRETS

• **Alert:** In formula card 1, notice Saguna involves physical idols while Nirguna rejects images; Andal was an Alvar woman saint, while Karaikkal Ammaiyar was a Nayanar woman saint.

• **Alert:** The Nalayira Divyaprabandham was frequently described by contemporaries as the 'Tamil Veda', claiming status equal to the four Sanskrit Vedas.

• **Alert:** Basavanna's followers were known as Virashaivas (heroes of Shiva) or Lingayats (wearers of the linga); they buried their dead rather than cremating them.

HIGH-YIELD CENTUM QUESTIONS & STEP-BY-STEP EXPLANATIONS

1. Distinguish between Saguna Bhakti and Nirguna Bhakti with examples of saints from each tradition. [Score: 3 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Saguna Bhakti:** Worship of the Divine in specific, concrete forms, human incarnations, and visual anthropomorphic deities with attributes. Examples: Mirabai, Chaitanya, Tulsidas, Surdas. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Nirguna Bhakti:** Worship of the Supreme Reality as formless, attribute-less, omnipresent, and transcendent beyond idols or temple rituals. Examples: Kabir, Guru Nanak, Ravidas. **[1.5 Marks]**

2. Explain the major features of the Bhakti movement initiated by the Alvars and Nayanars in Tamil Nadu. [Score: 4 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Devotional Focus:** Emerged in the 6th-9th centuries; Alvars were devoted to Vishnu and Nayanars were devoted to Shiva, traveling between shrines singing vernacular Tamil hymns. **[1 Mark]**

• **Social Inclusivity:** Welcomed all social strata, including lower castes, untouchables, and women who were traditionally excluded from Brahmanical Vedic rituals. **[1 Mark]**

• **Female Devotees:** Andal (an Alvar woman who saw herself as the beloved bride of Vishnu) and Karaikkal Ammaiyar (a Nayanar ascetic who adopted the form of a demoness) composed revered devotional poetry. **[1 Mark]**

• **Canonical Text:** Composed the Nalayira Divyaprabandham, which was revered as the 'Tamil Veda'. **[1 Mark]**

3. Discuss the Virashaiva (Lingayat) movement founded by Basavanna in Karnataka. [Score: 3 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Origin and Medium:** Initiated in the 12th century by Basavanna, a minister in the Kalachuri court; ideas spread through short poetic aphorisms called 'vachanas' in Kannada. **[1 Mark]**

• **Rejection of Caste and Brahmanism:** Challenged the caste hierarchy, questioned rebirth theories, rejected the sacrificial authority of the Vedas, and championed social equality. **[1 Mark]**

• **Social Innovations:** Encouraged widow remarriage, condemned child marriage, and practiced burial of the dead rather than cremation. **[1 Mark]**

4. Explain the reasons for the immense popularity of the Chishti Silsila in India. [Score: 4 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Khanqah Hospices:** Established open community hospices (khanqahs) welcoming people of all castes and faiths; Nizamuddin Auliya's khanqah in Delhi fed hundreds daily through voluntary offerings. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Adoption of Local Culture:** Adopted local Indian vernaculars (Hindavi), musical traditions (sama and qawwali), and spiritual poetry for mass emotional outreach. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Independence from State Power:** Maintained strict distance from royal court politics, preferring simple austere living and spiritual humility. **[1 Mark]**

5. How did Kabir express his critique of orthodox religious practices in his poetry? [Score: 3 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Rejection of Orthodoxy:** Criticized external rituals, idol worship, pilgrimage, and rigid dogma of both Hinduism (brahmins, sacred threads) and Islam (qazis, animal sacrifice). **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Syncretic Divine Names:** Used names from diverse traditions interchangeably: Allah, Rama, Khuda, Sahib, and Brahman to signify the single Formless Reality (Nirguna). **[1.5 Marks]**

6. State two fundamental teachings of Guru Nanak. **[Score: 2 Marks]**

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Teaching 1:** Advocated Nirguna bhakti, asserting that the Supreme God ('Rab') has no gender or form and is realized through inward meditation on the Divine Name (Shabad). **[1 Mark]**

• **Teaching 2:** Emphasized social equality by establishing the institution of Langar (community kitchen) where all people ate together irrespective of caste. **[1 Mark]**